

Planting Weeds:

The Structure of Disinformation Campaigns and Why They Work

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Abstract:

As the twenty-first century drags on it has become increasingly difficult to discuss the modern political landscape without bringing up disinformation. Disinformation (the intentional spread of false or misleading information in furtherance of a goal) has come to affect nearly every aspect of public life, from forcing authority figures into time consuming debunking efforts to fully controlling conversations on foundational issues. Although amorphous, disinformation exhibits many shared characteristics and markers that allow it to be effectively tracked and outed publicly as the malign influence it represents. However, for something so prevalent, there is often confusion over what disinformation actually is. This is compounded into an alarming issue when people acting in the political discourse are unable, or even unwilling, to identify pieces of disinformation.

But why is this? Why is something so divisive and toxic so omnipresent, effective, and difficult to prove to the very people affected by it? This article seeks to examine the structure and characteristics of disinformation, analyzing the components which make up a disinformation campaign, the psychology that allows it to flourish, and the lifecycle that disinformation often follows. In the latter half of the article we walk through a proven Russian disinformation campaign from the perspective of the disinformation actor, using real world examples to illustrate the concepts discussed and emphasize the potential impact of such malign influence efforts.

In the end, education on awareness, media literacy, and critical thinking skills are required to stem the swelling tide of disinformation. I hope that this article can serve as a useful educational resource for those looking to learn about disinformation and a convenient primer and reference for those that are already familiar with the subject.

When thinking about disinformation, whether it's online, on the news or even from our own lives, it's important to keep in mind just what disinformation is. Unlike misinformation, which is simply incorrect information, or malinformation, which presents largely accurate information in a misleading way, disinformation is a conscious attempt by an actor to spread misleading and/or false information to

further their goal. (GAO, 2022, p. 7) (An easy way that I remember these is that misinformation misses the mark, malinformation is malicious, and disinformation is disingenuous.)

Disinformation is not something that just happens or appears in our feeds. Rather, disinformation campaigns are always geared towards an objective, eliciting a behavioral change in a target audience that is beneficial to the originator. Understanding this, we can identify three prominent characteristics of disinformation, examine several psychological reasons why disinformation takes root, and look at how it actually spreads throughout an information environment. In this article, I will examine a case study of verifiable Russian disinformation, where a fabricated story of two mega yachts purchased with embezzled Ukrainian military aid made its way to the floor of the US House of Representatives.

Characteristics of Disinformation

Online disinformation is a hot button issue in today's academic and media landscape, with new and evolving tactics from disinformation actors and emerging scholarship on disinformation methodology popping up every day. Although this makes an "industry standard" of disinformation characteristics hard to settle on, from my experience disinformation is often defined by three main characteristics: it is targeted, it is convenient, and it is emotional.

Targeting an Audience

Influence—whether based on truth or lies, to build up a community or tear it down— always has a goal. To begin our discussion, I will define two terms: target audience and information environment. A target audience is a group of people or a specific community that a message or product is intended to reach and influence. The information environment is "the aggregate of individuals, organizations, and systems that collect, process, disseminate, or act on information," (GAO, 2022, p. 7) or simply put, the various pieces of information, platforms, and influencers available to a person or group. The influence process, whether applied by a marketing company or a Russian disinformation farm, is more or less the same. It relies on key psychological realities and basic planning tenets to achieve a goal, immaterial to whether that's buying a product or protesting a policy. For example, a ubiquitous marketing practice known as psychographics uses psychological variables such as attitudes, values, or fears to classify people into groups. (Merriam Webster) This research and analysis is then used to develop products and marketing designed to resonate specifically with them in the hopes of making a sale or increasing engagement. This is a form of researching, selecting and understanding a target audience, perhaps the most important part of the influence process carried out by all successful influence campaigns. A Government Accountability Office (GAO) report even mentions the potential for malign actors to engage in "micro-targeting" aimed at specific individuals or minute demographics. (GAO, 2022, P. 12) When analyzing potential target audiences, US Army Psychological Operations mainly asks four questions: What target audience will be most effective in accomplishing the desired behavior? What are the reasons for the target audience's current behavior? How does the target audience communicate and with whom? How can the target audience be influenced to achieve the desired behavior? (US Army, TM 3-53.11)

Disinformation is not magic, and simply exposing someone to it does not mean they will instantly accept it. However, by being targeted, disinformation drastically increases its odds of adoption. Influencers of all stripes will often keep in mind which target audiences are most likely to be nudged towards a desired behavior in order to raise their chances of success. It is far easier for an audience to take an action they believe is in line with their current behaviors than to completely pivot into a new one, as we will discuss below. Selecting a target audience and crafting a specific narrative for it is a process which requires understanding the target audience, how that audience thinks, what they like and what they dislike.

Disinformation may seem organic, in fact the best pieces do-- but every narrative, slogan and hashtag in a disinformation campaign is consciously geared towards a specific audience, a specific goal, and supporting a specific group or individual. In other words, disinformation campaigns are targeted. Disinformation actors will pick their target audience due to its ability to achieve the disinformation actor's goal and potentially its susceptibility to, or pre-existing alignment with, the disinformation goal. Whenever we look at a piece of disinformation, we need to remember that it is aimed at a specific goal and an audience to achieve that goal. As our examples will show, the message and narrative of effective disinformation will feed into the target audience's likes and dislikes; it will often be made to appear as if it's coming from within their community, and it will be written in such a way as to fall in line with the beliefs of that group.

With the wide variety of disinformation existing today, these are generalizations of successful disinformation efforts and not hard and fast rules. This is without even taking the quality of the disinformation into account, as some blatant disinformation may forgo all of the above and just try to wing it-- often with dubious results-- taking a shotgun approach by pushing out as many narratives as possible to see what sticks. Usually, the originator or the supported group behind the disinformation won't be self-evident, as pointing the finger at a group and exposing their manipulation is a (somewhat successful) technique to counter disinformation. (Bateman, Jackson, 2024) However, through analyzing the target audience, the goal, and the environment in which the disinformation is released, we can make an educated stab at who is behind it and certainly who benefits from the narrative.

Research from Todd C. Helmus and Kurt Klein reminds us that "the metrics used to evaluate counter-messaging efforts should align with the messenger's desired outcome, which is not always a direct change in the original speaker's belief or behavior." (Helmus, Klein, 2018) When conducting this backwards analysis, it is important to remain cognizant that the target audience and disinformation actor would both benefit from the disingenuous narrative, but often for their own, different reasons.

Convenience, Confirmation and Anchoring Bias

This brings us to the second characteristic: convenience. It's not enough for a disinformation campaign to throw out the perfect, most supportive narrative glistening with sympathy into the world and hope that it gets picked up by the target audience. The target audience has to like the message and believe that the narrative supports its own views or aims. In other words, the disinformation has to be extremely convenient, if true. Convenience is another way for me to refer to the logical fallacy of confirmation bias. Confirmation bias is "the tendency to process information by looking for, or

interpreting, information that is consistent with one's existing beliefs." (Luebering, 2025) Of note, Encyclopedia Britannica, whose definition I just quoted, also makes a point to mention that confirmation bias is especially likely to occur "when an issue is highly important or self-relevant." (Luebering, 2025)

Northeastern University has collected evidence which shows that "fake news" relies on abusing this cognitive shortcut to spread, stating: "when it comes to our interaction with 'fake news' we are much more likely to agree with information that matches what we want to be true, and are less likely to verify information that confirms our beliefs. This is largely how 'fake news' spreads as misinformation, we are not deliberately trying to share false information with our friends and family, but we may genuinely believe it is true because we want it to be." (Northeastern, 2025) The authors of *The Misinformation Age* quote a study on confirmation bias which showed that when subjects were presented with conflicting evidence on a wide range of topics, they became more entrenched in their preexisting beliefs, despite what they were shown. (O'Connor, Weatherall, P. 76)

Another prominent cognitive bias is anchoring bias, where people tend to overly rely on the first information they receive or rely on pre-existing information when making decisions. (Eldridge, 2023) The first thing people tend to see is the first thing they tend to believe, which gives disinformation an insidious edge. When a disinformation actor creates a fake story, they are, by definition, the first person to "break" that story and push it to an audience. This bias is particularly harmful in the spread of disinformation through trusted sources and preexisting informational pathways. If an influencer or news outlet spreads a false story, their followers are more likely to receive the disinformation first before sources they follow less closely or not at all. To create an example, a piece of disinformation about dogs being better than cats and a truthful story about cats being better than dogs are both published at the same time. Jimmy receives his daily news from XYZ Daily and occasional stories from QWER Weekly in his social media feed. If XYZ Daily publishes the disinformation and QWER Weekly publishes the truthful story, Jimmy will more likely be exposed to the disinformation first and perceive the truthful information from QWER Weekly as incorrect. If XYZ Daily aligns with Jimmy's political views that dogs are better than cats, then confirmation bias can compound this effect further, making the politically inconvenient and second seen QWER Weekly truthful information—that cats are superior—far less likely to be believed.

Disinformation must be spread by people who are not part of the originating group in order to become adopted by the target audience. To do that, the disinformation needs to provide an incentive to be spread, which usually manifests in people wanting either to discuss or support it. If a piece of disinformation creates a perfect talking point for a group, particularly political ones, it will be more likely to gain acceptance in the same way that a talking point from a Congressional staffer or media group is adopted and parroted. Research from the Carnegie Endowment notes this reality, stating that traditional political advocacy can be hard to distinguish from messaging campaigns that use storytelling or emotional appeals on narrative and psychological levels. (Bateman, Jackson, 2024, p. 3)

To summarize, disinformation needs to provide a motivation for its target audience to believe and spread it. This usually takes the form of a narrative supporting their preexisting views, which provides the target audience with a convenient support for their current beliefs and values.

Disinformation, however, often builds on this by introducing an emotional aspect to their convenient disinformation, treading into the more traditional waters of propaganda.

Emotional Appeals and Propaganda

The third ingredient in a successful disinformation campaign is emotion. It is well documented (and probably something that you can prove with your own experience) that an emotional message is better at spurring an audience to action and shortcutting critical thinking in decision making. This is often referred to as Affect Heuristic, “a valuation based on the subject’s positive or negative mood or emotional reaction,” (McDonough, 2025) or in other words the tendency to use emotions and feelings toward a subject in lieu of objective facts as a short cut in decision making. Affect Heuristic (heuristics being a mental shortcut people use in decision making) can affect all kinds of critical thought, from whether or not you believe someone to investing in a company because it “feels right.” When I say emotional, I don’t just mean happy or sad. I also mean righteous, correct, superior ...and the list goes on.

An emotional story makes people more invested and less likely to think critically and go with the “facts” as presented, something noted even by financial professionals when researching investment trends. In *Narrative and Numbers*, Stern Professor Aswath Damodaran discusses both neurological and psychological evidence which shows both our brains and our thought processes are altered when we listen to a good story or become accepting of a narrative. Furthermore, emotional narratives and taglines are remembered more easily, for longer periods of time, and with stronger opinions than just numbers and facts alone. (Damodaran, p. 11-13) A good narrative, Damodaran argues, is an instrumental part of a company’s successful valuation and has led to even seasoned investors making costly errors because strong emotional attachment to a company’s story interrupted critical thought. Emotional resonance also makes people more willing to act upon the information and spread it on their own. Studies performed by neuroeconomist Paul Zak measured an increase in oxytocin levels in subjects when they found a story or narrative emotionally compelling. In an experiment using a video asking for charity donations, Zak was able to show an increase in donations commensurate with the increase in oxytocin from the emotional appeals in the video. (Damodaran, p. 14)

The best stories require their audience to make the connections themselves. The storyteller may have a clear emotion or conclusion they want the audience to reach, but simply telling the audience how to feel won’t allow that conclusion to sink in as opposed to the audience believing it is their own rationale. This “illusory truth effect” is a basic persuasive tool, and something that a short and simple piece of disinformation can ironically excel at when it requires the audience to “fill in the blanks” with their own preconceived notions and biases. Short snippets of disinformation, such as a fake tweet or the headline of a fabricated article, also benefit from being more easily repeatable and shareable.

Research from the National Library of Medicine also supports the fact that “repeated statements are rated as subjectively truer than comparable new statements, even though repetition alone provides no new, probative information.” (Henderson, Simons, Barr, 2021, Abstract) This can help explain one part of why people tend to believe more widely spread disinformation, as they see it multiple times from multiple people and sources. Building on the principle of convenience above, quick, easily digestible and emotionally resonant disinformation narratives are tailor-made to take advantage of this.

Various propaganda techniques are designed to take advantage of these and other logical fallacies and cognitive biases. Through my own research on ISIS propaganda, I’ve seen disinformation form the basis of hundreds of pieces of propaganda. Lies, half-truths, and even complete truths are consistently paired with certain heuristics or psychological appeals to engineer targeted messages. I’ve

observed this in topics ranging from supporting ISIS governmental initiatives to ISIS trying to enforce a ban on Apple products in their territory. In the Apple case specifically, an ISIS internal decree tied the risks created by GPS and other functions of “products of the Apple network” to “protect[-ing] the souls of the soldiers of the Islamic State and their possessions in the shadow of the fierce Crusader campaign against the state of the Caliphate.” (Schmid, 2018, p. 140-141)

Although propaganda techniques are not always present in disinformation, they can often form the scaffolding for such disinformation, providing a psychological structure for the disinformation author to build off of. The Institute for Propaganda Analysis, a counterpropaganda think tank from pre-World War Two America, coined seven common types of propaganda devices which are laid out below. (Schmid, 2018, p. 17-20) Although dated and slightly simplistic, these still bear weight today.

Name Calling: Preying on hate and fear, the propagandist attaches negative names and their associated stereotype “to those individuals, groups, nations, races, policies, practices, beliefs, and ideals which he would have us condemn and reject.” One of the most common forms of propaganda, “name Calling is a device to make us form a judgment to reject and condemn, without examining the evidence.” This is often seen in disinformation when creating catchy headlines or accusatory sentences intended to be shared and parroted ad nauseum by the target audience.

Glittering Generalities: The opposite of name calling, “the propagandist identifies his program with virtue by use of “virtue words.” “Here he appeals to our emotions of love, generosity, and brotherhood... All persons of good will believe in these ideals.” This technique attaches a “shining ideal” to the goals of an organization in order “to make us accept and approve without examining the evidence.” This is used functionally the same way as name calling in disinformation, with the difference being that the disinformation is trying to bolster the support or image of a particular individual, group or event.

Card Stacking: “[The propagandist] stacks the cards against the truth. He uses under-emphasis and overemphasis to dodge issues and evade facts. He resorts to lies, censorship, and distortion. He omits facts. He offers false testimony.” Card stacking is essentially the propagandist lying and distorting the truth in order to support their narrative, creating false facts or modified retellings of events. Its use in disinformation is self-explanatory, although sometimes card stacking is used to divert attention by selectively editing out facts that might point out who benefits most from the false narrative.

Transfer: “A device by which the propagandist carries over the authority, sanction, and prestige of something we respect and revere to something he would have us accept.” Transfer is an appeal to authority wherein the support of an organization, such as a church or government, is used to bolster the credibility and appeal of something that would normally be rejected. In disinformation, this is used when citing vague “independent journalists” or “government officials” in order to appear legitimate without actually citing any verifiable individuals.

Testimonial: Similar to transfer, testimonial is a way for a propagandist to get third party support for their goals by creating false quotes from people, or indeed creating fake people entirely, relevant to the propagandist’s audience. This is used in disinformation when citing vague “witnesses” or when making a statement and then attributing it to someone relevant, (or even completely fictional), to the information

or target audience. This is done without providing any material or faked support for their claims, “this anonymous or random person saw it happen, therefore it must be true.”

Plain Folk: This is where the propagandist claims they’re just like you, a normal person doing what a normal person would do. With this technique the propagandist tries to appear as a member of the audience, claiming an in-group credibility. Politicians use this all the time when campaigning, eating hot dogs and drinking beer trying to appear as down to earth and “normal” as possible. It would not be wrong to understand this device as the propagandist trying to come across as a neighborhood friend, with the same wants, desires, and grievances as their audience.

Disinformation actors use this technique when spreading a story through false accounts on social media or when initially creating a story by having it delivered by someone claiming to be an average worker or bystander affected by the fake event. This is seen in a video where a woman claims to be an employee of Cartier jewelry who was fired after Ukrainian President Zelensky’s wife bought a million dollars’ worth of jewelry, was incredibly rude, and demanded the employee be let go. (StopFake.org, 2024) Fake accounts do their best to pose as an average American, in some cases literally posting “I am an American.” (Klepper, 2024)

Band Wagon: This “is a device to make us follow the crowd, to accept the propagandist's program en masse. Here his theme is: ‘Everybody's doing it.’” If your friends jumped off a cliff, would you jump too? If the propagandist is using band wagon propaganda, then yes, they hope you would. Disinformation uses this similarly to testimonial and plain folk to imply that the disinformation is the dominant narrative and is already adopted as truth by either the target audience or the majority of “reasonable” people. This takes advantage of in-group bias, which we will cover later on.

In my own research on ISIS propaganda, I’ve found that atrocity propaganda is extremely relevant when looking at disinformation during times of war or when disinformation is seeking to discredit a government. (Schmid, p. 41-50) It’s important to note that when it comes to atrocity propaganda, the research conducted was on actual atrocities and war crimes, but nevertheless I believe the same underlying principles for why it works also apply to less extreme examples.

The goal of atrocity propaganda is to demonize an individual, group, or identity by accusing them of committing horrible acts, atrocities. By doing this, the propagandist will, in a rather simplistic way, paint their opponent in the worst light possible in the hopes of creating an emotional response in their target audience. When it came to Jihadist propaganda, the atrocities they accused coalition forces of included things like illegal bombing and attacks on civilians (ironically), but that was specifically considering their target audience of sympathizers and internal supporters. If our target audience is fiscally concerned citizens, then embezzlement, misallocation of funds and other financial crimes would reasonably (to an obviously lesser extent) function in the same way as traditional atrocities in propaganda. If financial responsibility is the number one concern of the target audience, then it’s reasonable to say that accusations of fiscal irresponsibility are the quickest logical path to spur some form of action within the target audience.

Most people don’t read past the headline (one French study even showed that 59% of shared URLs are never actually clicked on), and if that headline is emotional, they will have even less reason to

actually read and investigate the story. (Gabiellkov, Ramachandran, Chaintreau, Legout, 2016) A successful disinformation campaign, by its very nature of being false or misleading, cannot have people conduct effective research or believe presented research if it conflicts with the disinformation. Getting the audience to feel righteous anger or comforting joy can endear them to the disingenuous narrative and make it difficult to put those feelings aside and objectively analyze it. How many times have you seen someone confronted with clear proof that they were wrong—but refuse to believe the evidence? As the saying goes, you can't reason someone out of something they did not reason themselves into.

Why Disinformation Spreads

Taking some of the key points we discussed above—that successful disinformation targets specific groups, appears to support those groups' goals and opinions, and has a component of personal emotional appeal in them—we can discuss how disinformation spreads. We established what shapes the actual message, but we need to take a further look at psychological and societal factors to explain why these messages actually spread within a community.

Disinformation spreads by hijacking the natural flow of information in communities, where information flows from trusted actors and accepted platforms to achieve either orthodoxy or irrelevance, potentially even closing off communities from outside information. In *The Misinformation Age*, UC Irvine professors Cailin O'Connor and Jaems Weatherall perform studies that, with the aid of mathematical social learning models, show how misinformation can spread among completely rational actors. They note that “many of our beliefs-- perhaps most of them-- have a more complex origin: we form them on the basis of what others tell us... for someone trying to adjudicate only on the basis of what he or she hears from others, it is hard to separate the true from the false. Most of us get our false beliefs from the same places we get our true ones...” (O'Connor, Weatherall, p. 8-9) In other words, as a society we require the opinions and firsthand accounts of others to inform our own world view.

It is inherently impossible to see everything at once or be an expert in every field (despite what comments on social media say to the contrary), no matter how educated or traveled we are. Although O'Connor and Weatherall's work is primarily aimed at the spread of misinformation, we can take the principles explored in *The Misinformation Age* and apply it to the spread of disinformation as well. Both misinformation and disinformation spread similarly, as they are both incorrect information, the difference being disinformation is injected and encouraged more artificially than misinformation alone.

There is a social tendency to more readily accept information as fact if it comes from personally known or trusted sources, or in other words from within the community. The work in *Misinformation Age* shows that the distance between nodes in a network and the degree of trust between them dramatically alters how information travels. If a close and trusted source shares a piece of information, it is far likelier to be believed than a further and less trusted source. (O'Connor, Weatherall, p. 71) These findings are a good mathematical support for in-group bias, which, as the name implies, is the “tendency to favor one's own group, its members, its characteristics, and its products, particularly in reference to other groups.” (APA, 2018)

The more an information node appears to be a known quantity in the community, the more it will be trusted over an unknown or external authority figure. People will tend to believe a neighbor they

respect more than a researcher they have never heard of. This extends to leaders within a group and can help explain why individuals will believe false information spread by their chosen political representative and disbelieve factual information spread by a political opponent.

In creating an evidence-based policy guide on countering disinformation, the Carnegie Endowment states that “evidence from fact-checking studies shows that corrective measures against disinformation are more effective when the speaker belongs to the same party as the audience (and are less effective when they do not).” (Bateman, Jackson, 2024) Carnegie Endowment research again supports this with research showing “the rhetoric of political elites, programming on traditional media sources like TV, and narratives circulating among trusted community members are all highly influential in shaping people’s speech, beliefs, and behaviors.” (Bateman, Jackson, 2024) To explain this further, we will next take a look at conformity bias.

O’Connor and Weatherall point to conformity bias as a reason for the spread and potential resilience of misinformation, where an individual makes their decision solely based on what the majority of their group has decided regardless of the evidence presented to them. Once finding its place in the official narrative of a group, acceptance of a piece of information, whether true or false, can serve as a type of litmus test for membership to that group. Especially when it comes to information that doesn’t bring any immediate consequences (whether or not a person believes in evolution, for example, won’t have any practical impact on their life in the same way not believing in stop signs would), espousing a certain belief to gain social acceptance outweighs the potential consequences of the belief itself.

O’Connor and Weatherall remark that “when beliefs are not very important to action, they can come to take the role of a kind of social signal. They tell people which group you belong to—and help you get whatever benefits might accrue from membership in that group... When two cliques settle on two different beliefs, those beliefs come to signal group membership. A man who says he does not believe in evolution tells you something not just about his beliefs but about where he comes from and whom he identifies with.” (O’Connor, Weatherall, 2022, p. 90-91) They also note the phenomena of “information cascade,” where “a belief can spread through a group despite the presence of strong evidence to the contrary. In these cases, incorrect statements... can snowball as people’s judgements are influenced by others in their social environment.” (O’Connor, Weatherall, 2022, p. 80-82)

These psychosocial phenomena help explain how disinformation can be so quickly adopted and so hard to shift in a community once an idea or issue becomes political. Imbued with political energy, any idea or news story can become a litmus test for group orthodoxy. You can actually see this phenomenon at work on social media posts whenever there is a disaster or national event. Everyone suddenly has an opinion on a niche topic, but almost none of them are original. I have found that these opinions rarely diverge too much once solidified, and the vast majority of social media posts are regurgitating a handful of talking points that gained primacy in their community early on. The US 2020 presidential election, Hunter Biden’s laptop, the US Mexico border, twitter vs X, Diversity Equity and Inclusion training, student loans; if someone identifies as either Republican or Democrat you can have a pretty good idea of what their opinion will be on those subjects without ever talking to them. This is why disinformation is so dangerous in a partisan political landscape, for if a piece of disinformation becomes adopted widely enough as a political fact, it may never stop haunting the country.

Information, and sometimes the beliefs that follow it, travels along social and institutional pathways in a more or less defined manner. Disinformation takes advantage of these natural pathways like a parasite, infecting individuals and groups and spreading like a cognitive disease throughout communities in the same way truthful information and news spreads. The good news of this is that this means disinformation is trackable and traceable as much as any other piece of information, if not more so. With this in mind, we will now look at the structure of a disinformation campaign.

The Life Cycle of Disinformation

Disinformation campaigns, like other types of information campaigns, have a life cycle comprised of broad but observable phases. Generally, this begins with the injection of disinformation into the information environment through “illegitimate” means—such as official state-sponsored accounts, AI bots, surrogates or supporters. Simply put, the disinformation actor publishes disinformation into the information environment any way that they can, usually not directly to the target audience. In many cases this takes the form of small or clearly new online accounts posting a story or posing as a whistleblower leaking information. This initial information injection is then be picked up by more established accounts or proxies in order for it to spread to the first nodes in the target audience. The goal of this technique is to create an appearance of real reporting and provide disinformation spreaders a citable source to appear more legitimate.

After this initial injection, the disinformation needs to be adopted and shared by genuine members of the target audience: the best-case scenario being a leader or well-known figure within the target audience known as a key communicator. This phase is where most campaigns fail, unable to gain traction within the target audience and spread from non-disinformation actors. If disinformation gains a foothold in the target audience, it enters the final phase and actually begins influencing the actions of the target audience in line with the disinformation actor’s goal.

When tracing disinformation, I find it both extremely important and extremely interesting to note that certain key phrases and word choices are repeated verbatim throughout the life cycle. This allows researchers to trace the spread of disinformation by searching for these more or less unique markers of the disinformation. Work from US Army veteran, Open-Source Intelligence (OSINT) professional and disinformation researcher Ryan McBeth illustrates this phenomenon on numerous occasions. For example, McBeth was able to trace a Russian disinformation campaign in the wake of Hurricane Helene’s destruction in North Carolina by tracing the verbatim repetition of the phrase “10 Billion to Ukraine” from legitimate social media users all the way to its first mention by Russian bots. (McBeth, 2023, 2024)

Key communicators are as varied as the communities they come from and take the form of influencers on social media all the way to US Senators. Key communicators are critical to a successful disinformation campaign due to their reach and trusted status within their community. If a key communicator shares a piece of disinformation they unwittingly (or wittingly) launder the disinformation within their group, i.e. obscure the disinformation’s origin as a coordinated campaign from an external or malicious source. These key communicators provide two of the most important ingredients for a successful disinformation campaign: legitimacy and dedicated followers with the target audience.

Their laundering obscures the nefarious origin of the disinformation to the lay person and reduces suspicion that the disinformation is, in fact, disinformation. In their leadership or social roles, these key communicators also create more engagement than the disinformation author could ever hope to achieve on their own. A key communicator's potential for widespread and trusted exposure gives disinformation its best chance at taking root, either within the group as a whole or with enough members of the group to accomplish its objective. As discussed above, "clean" information which appears to be widely spread from within a target audience seems much more credible to that target audience. Adoption by one group may also grant enough legitimacy to spread it to other audiences, where the cycle continues. Once fully adopted, the likelihood that a target audience will identify the disinformation is very low, as it has become the group's preferred talking point for any or all of the reasons described above.

Building off of his studies and field work, Ryan McBeth coined the "MAGIC disinformation Kill Chain" to describe the life cycle of Russian disinformation. (McBeth, 2024) McBeth's work also provides practical examples and support for the findings of O'Connor and Weatherall, specifically by providing practical examples of real time information flows within a group and the natural reliance on experts and "on the ground" sources to form opinions. The Russian tactics laid out in the MAGIC kill chain are being increasingly adopted by both state and non-state actors around the world as standard tactics for a disinformation campaign. MAGIC stands for:

MAKE the goal- Decide what outcome the disinformation will create.

ACQUIRE the target- Decide who will be susceptible (whether low information or politically aligned) and able to create the desired outcome.

GENERATE the disinformation- Create the narrative and key phrases to resonate with the target audience using the characteristics of the target audience and disinformation goal. McBeth emphasizes that when analyzing a disinformation campaign, the same sentences or verbiage created in this phase and spread in the infiltrate phase can be seen repeated verbatim and used to track disinformation to its origin.

INFILTRATE the target- Use seeding accounts to spread the disinformation, often by posing as the target audience, and encourage the adoption of the disinformation by the target audience. This is where the illegitimate means of bots, paid proxies, and state media comes into play. McBeth notes the use of "counterfeit conservatives," Russian paid individuals who push Russian disinformation campaigns under the guise of having genuine American conservative principles. Tenet Media, a group of conservative influencers under investigation for taking Russian payments to spread Russia Times talking points, is an example. (McBeth, 2024)

CASCADE the amplification- The disinformation is spread by influencers and key communicators within the target audience, yielding a massive spread of the disinformation from trusted members of the target audience. Regular members also spread the information to their immediate contacts. This is the ultimate goal of the disinformation campaign in terms of spreading.

Once spread in this manner, the disinformation will either jump to a new target audience and spread further, become the accepted truth within the target audience, or both. It is an unfortunate reality that once a piece of disinformation becomes adopted by a group, it is difficult to convince them that their belief stems from disinformation. A Government Accountability Office report on the subject laments that “targets are susceptible to disinformation that fits their beliefs, attitudes, and worldviews. This can lead targets to increase their reliance on disinformation and in some instances make them resistant to attempts to “correct” their views causing them to more strongly accept disinformation.” (GAO, p. 7) *Misinformation Age* studies also support this, noting results that show people “simply stop listening at some point and do not update their beliefs at all on the basis of evidence produced by someone who disagrees with them too much.” (O’Connor, Weatherall, p. 72)

The disinformation campaign is deemed successful by the disinformation actor if it causes the target audience to actually take actions benefiting the disinformation goal, such as protesting a policy or pulling financial support to a group. As we will see in our case study, by understanding the structure of disinformation and the principles that allow it to be successful, we can both identify and trace disinformation to its source.

A Tale of Two Yachts

In 2023 a story was shared by Congresswoman Marjorie Taylor Greene with the caption “Anyone who votes to fund Ukraine is funding the most corrupt money scheme of any foreign war in our country’s history. And forcing the American people to pay for it.” She linked an article from a think tank which in turn cited a news article publishing leaked information from an independent journalist. The story? Ukrainian President Zelensky had purchased two mega yachts during the height of the Russian invasion, likely with embezzled US military aid. The journalist provided pictures of receipts and documents proving the purchase of the yachts. Representative Greene used her post to support attempts to block US military aid to Ukraine and urge her followers to do the same. However, the yachts mentioned were still for sale. The story shared by a member of the US House of Representatives to influence foreign policy was a Russian disinformation campaign.

Having explored the principles of disinformation, we will now take an in-depth look at a successful Russian disinformation campaign, both in how it was constructed and why we can say it was successful from the Russian point of view. The yacht story is a good case study because of how easily verifiable it is as Russian disinformation and because it achieved its goal: influencing policy for US military aid to Ukraine. We step into the shoes of a Russian disinformation actor and reverse engineer this disinformation campaign, starting with the goal: reduce US support to Ukrainian military aid; identification of the audience: Fiscally conservative members of the US opposition party (at that time—Republicans); creation of the message: targeted, convenient, and emotional; initial injection: YouTube to Russian proxy sites; incubation: entering online discourse and spreading through references and links; to acceptance (and rejection) by key communicators: Republican lawmakers.

Since Russia’s first overt military incursion into Ukraine in 2014, Russia has been utilizing propaganda and disinformation to destabilize the relationship between the US and Ukraine. (GEC, 2020) With the Russian invasion of 2022 and its initial failures, disinformation attempts have ramped up as the

Russian military began facing severe mounting losses in large part to foreign military aid flooding into Ukraine. From this standpoint, an obvious goal for a Russian disinformation campaign would be to reduce foreign military aid in order to prevent the buildup of Ukrainian combat power. To narrow this goal further, the largest backer of the Ukrainian military is currently the US, which has sent over \$69 billion in military assistance since 2014, with nearly \$66 billion of that since 2022. (US Department of State, 2025) From the Russian perspective, a disinformation campaign would be effective if it prevents or delays US military aid to Ukraine.

Now that we have the goal, the next step is to determine the correct target audience. Opposition parties are defined political entities with their own reasons to challenge the governing administration and the status quo. During the Biden administration, a large section of the Republican party was (and continues to be) already opposed to the Biden administration's foreign aid as a matter of fiscal or foreign policy.

On the more hardline side of the Republican party, a niche faction of roughly three dozen conservative members of the US House of Representatives, the Freedom Caucus, is diametrically opposed to sending military aid to Ukraine with, in their words, "no offset and no security for our own wide-open borders." (Schnell, 2024) Representative Marjorie Taylor Greene (who was booted from the Freedom Caucus in 2023) is vehemently opposed to sending military aid to Ukraine; she brought forth legislation several times in her attempts to stop aid entirely and even attacked House Speaker Mike Johnson for allowing a vote on US military aid to Ukraine to proceed (which 112 Republicans also voted against), stating the Speaker "is absolutely working for the Democrats. He's passing the Biden administration's agenda. Mike Johnson's speakership is over. He needs to do the right thing, to resign." (Bekiempis, 2024) In addition to this, Tenet Media, a group of right-wing influencers on the same portion of the political spectrum as our proposed target audience, was recently embroiled in a scandal where the US Department of Justice indicted two Russian nationals for paying Tenet Media to push Russian influence in the US. (Department of Justice, 2024)

The issue of Tenet Media is a piece of evidence which shows our target audience likely being repeatedly targeted by Russian propagandists. These members of Congress and their supporters have the ability to destabilize the US aid process, a pre-existing motivation to do so, and a history of being influenced by other disinformation campaigns. As shown by the cast of characters who ended up spreading the disinformation, it is reasonable to say that Americans with these characteristics were the target audience of the yacht disinformation.

Now, with the goal and target audience decided, Russian disinformation planners needed to craft the message. Given their target audience and goal, a good disinformation narrative would latch on to pre-existing discourse and sentiment. A natural starting point would be opposition to what the target audience describes as irresponsible foreign aid to a country with corruption issues. This is an even better starting point when considering Ukraine's very real problematic history with corruption stemming from, ironically, its time under Russian influence. (Vohra, 2024) As the saying goes, 'the best lies have a kernel of truth.'

A Russian disinformation planner would also have several years of disinformation data to draw upon, and likely noted the success of narratives claiming that "Ukraine's government is too corrupt to benefit from Western aid and that the Biden family has alleged corrupt ties to Ukraine." (De Luce, Asghar,

2024) Given this research on the target audience's current beliefs and susceptibility, a good narrative could create an example of Ukrainian corruption which took full advantage of concerns about American money being wasted. A way to make this appeal more emotional would be to center it around a symbol of decadence and corrupt politicians: A mega yacht— and why just one, why not two fully furnished and ludicrously expensive ones that would be recognized as a powerful symbol of embezzlement and corruption for the target audience.

With economic issues such as inflation driving up the costs of essentials such as groceries, gasoline and rent in America, it's an easy bet that a story about government spending enabling corrupt foreign officials to buy yachts would have an emotional resonance. Frankly, the story is meant to piss people off by insinuating taxpayer money that should be supporting their local communities during a time of need is instead being handed out to foreigners and stolen right before their very eyes. As comments on social media will show, it worked. The dominant themes spread with this disinformation were anger, disgust, and a call to block future funding to Ukraine.

To consolidate what we have so far: the Russian goal is to stop or delay military aid from the US to Ukraine; the target audience is composed of certain conservative members of Congress and their supporters fiscally and politically opposed to supporting Ukraine; and the narrative is aimed specifically at military aid to Ukraine, supports the target audience's preexisting beliefs, and contains an emotional appeal to anger with an example of gross corruption during a time of economic hardship for many Americans. With the foundation set, we can now take a look at how the disinformation actually spread in the information environment. We will see that the yacht disinformation gained traction primarily due to its emotional appeal and providing a perfectly curated attack line the target audience could use to show their frustration with the Biden administration and a very specific aspect of US foreign policy.

YouTube to Yachts

To inject the disinformation into the info blood stream of the world, Russian disinformation actors created a YouTube account, owned and operated by an alleged independent journalist named Shahzad Nasir, and published the story with forged documents and vague sources. (Russian Disinformation Nasir, 2023) At first glance this may seem odd and phishy, as the account only had one other video and 132 subscribers as of February 2024, but publicity and inscrutability were not the intent with the YouTube account.

The actual intent was to provide a factual looking basis for the disinformation, a piece of "breaking journalism" that other disinformation outlets were merely reporting on. From here on out, every outlet, account or influencer talking about the disinformation is now citing a source, appearing more legitimate and removed from any potential political sponsorship or direction. The "story" was then picked up by DC Weekly, who ran an article attacking the Ukrainian president, showing pictures of the alleged yachts and documents allegedly confirming the sale. The DC Weekly article also linked to the original video. (Russian Disinformation Devlin, 2023) A separate website, called the Islander, also picked up the "story" from the YouTube account, publishing an extremely similar article to DC Weekly. (Russian Disinformation Datsyuk, 2023) I suspect that these websites not only serve similar functions but are, if not physically run by the same individuals, directed by the same organization. The construction of both

articles and the websites themselves are nearly identical in their writing styles, word choices and type of articles posted (possibly due to using the same AI programming to fill out most of the website, creating more articles to make the sites appear legitimate).

For example, note the similarities between the first sentences of each article:

The Islander: “In the heart of Eastern Europe, where the tumult of war clashes with the allure of Western support, a seismic scandal unfolds, casting a long shadow over Ukraine’s leadership”

DC Weekly: “In the heart of Eastern Europe, where the shadows of conflict and the glimmers of Western support intermingle, a new controversy has surfaced, casting a long shadow over Ukraine’s embattled leadership.”

Most importantly, the information within the yacht articles in question is practically identical. Both cite the YouTube video, use identical screenshots, and also post the same image to thumbnail their articles. The future use by other disinformation spreaders as a cited source is likewise identical. The original YouTube video, DC Weekly and The Islander articles were also published on November 23rd, 24th, and 26th respectively.

From here the story spread quickly across multiple platforms, being linked, referenced, and forming the basis of further articles and videos on social media. Each of these steps further removed the “story” from the original Russian disinformation actor.

A user on X (previously Twitter) with over half a million followers named “Lord Bebo” posted a screenshot of the DC Weekly article, writing “UAUSEU 🇺🇦 !! BREAKING: Zelensky buys Yacht "Lucky me" and "My Legacy" for \$75 million. -> You're welcome @ZelenskaUA and @ZelenskyyUa! I hope you both enjoy that little something you got with our taxes!” This post was viewed over 236,000 times and reposted 600 times. (@MyLordBebo, 2023) Another X user, Kim Dotcom, referenced the Islander article and posted several images of the luxury yachts, writing “US tax dollars at work. Zelenskyy allegedly bought 2 yachts via proxy worth over \$75 million as reported by The Islander. The names of the yachts are an insult to all Ukrainians: ‘Lucky me’ and ‘My Legacy’”. (@KimDotcom, 2023) His account has over 1.7 million followers, and his post was reposted over 8,400 times.

A British TikTok user under the name “@Chiscork89,” who has over 300,000 followers and videos routinely getting millions of views, posted a reaction video to a Rumble video clip from American conservative talk show host and ex-Fox News anchor Clayton Morris. In the clip, Morris discusses Zelensky purchasing the Yachts for \$75 million and uses the exact imagery from the fabricated DC Weekly and The Islander articles on air to push the narrative of President Zelensky embezzling US military aid funds (in addition to referencing an additional unrelated disinformation story). @Chiscork89 ends his reaction video by decrying the amount of money the UK gives to Ukraine and urges viewers to watch the video he cited. (@Chiscork89, Clayton Morris, 2023) A grouping of videos on TikTok labeled “Everything Zelensky and Wife Has Bought” collects videos claiming to show lavish spending habits of the Presidential couple. This collection contains mostly if not solely disinformation including a video on our yacht story. (TikTok, 2025)

As we analyze this disinformation campaign, keep in mind the fact that disinformation shared from a centralized source will almost always have similarities in the shared material. Whether it is the

same doctored images, the same erroneous facts or even the same tagline, disinformation campaigns can be traced by those similarities once one of them is suspected or proven to be disinformation. I use these examples to show two things: the importance of key communicators in spreading disinformation and to highlight the sheer amount of reposts specifically. Each repost and share represents a new person turning into a node in the disinformation network. They become a new spreader, a new conversation about the yacht, and perhaps the disinformation's entry point into an entirely new information environment.

As mentioned in the previous sections, people tend to believe information more when it is shared by someone close to them and when they are exposed to it repeatedly. Each repost and share represents an opportunity for a person to spread disinformation to those closest to them and further weave the web of manipulation.

Yachts on the Congressional Floor

At this point we have gone from a problem Russian disinformation actors need to solve all the way to a successfully widespread piece of disinformation. The disinformation has spread, but it still hasn't achieved its goal. To see if the Russian propagandists were successful, we need to take a look at the actions taken by the target audience to disrupt US military aid to Ukraine. In this case, we will examine several Republican figures in the US government: one who completely fell for the disinformation, one who was exposed to it and rejected it as disinformation, and one who adopted the narrative likely only on a superficial level.

I am focusing on the Republican lawmakers as a whole for a couple of reasons. The first and most important is that the proposed target audience we are using is part of the Republican party, but not the entire Republican party. Senior Republican leaders have lamented that Russian disinformation is making its way into the information environment of their fellow Republican lawmakers. Representative McCaul, Chair of the House Foreign Affairs Committee, stated that "Russian propaganda has made its way into the United States, unfortunately, and it's infected a good chunk of my party's base," and Representative Turner, Chair of the House Permanent Select Committee on Intelligence, alarmingly remarked that antiUkraine messages from Russian sources are "being uttered on the House floor." (De Luce, Asghar, 2024) It is important to bear in mind that a piece of disinformation entering into someone's information environment does not mean they are the target nor that they are inherently susceptible to it. The Republican party, and the various reactions of its members to the yacht story, illustrates this fact well.

To begin with an obvious marker of success for the disinformation campaign, we can look at the actions of Representative Greene regarding US military aid to Ukraine. On November 27th, 2023, the Congresswoman tweeted: "Anyone who votes to fund Ukraine is funding the most corrupt money scheme of any foreign war in our country's history. And forcing the American people to pay for it," linking to an article from the Strategic Culture Foundation, which itself links to the article from the Islander. (Plummer, 2023; Greene, 2023) The Strategic Culture Foundation was officially sanctioned by the US Department of the Treasury on April 15th, 2021, as "an online journal registered in Russia that is directed by the SVR and closely affiliated with the Russian Ministry of Foreign Affairs... It publishes conspiracy theorists, giving them a broader platform to spread disinformation, while trying to obscure the Russian

origins of the journal so that readers may be more likely to trust the sourcing.” (US Dep. Treasury, 2021) The Congresswoman’s tweet is proof that the Russian disinformation is influencing their target audience to fiercely oppose, in a tangible way through legislation and voting, further US military aid to Ukraine. It also illustrates the Russian nesting doll of information laundering. Examining this from the perspective of one of Congresswoman Greene’s supporters reading the tweet, the information is four times removed from the Russian disinformation actor who originally created the disinformation, as shown below:

Russian Propagandist ➡ YouTube “journalist” ➡ The Islander ➡ The Strategic Culture Foundation ➡ US Congresswoman ➡ Supporter

This illustrates the goal of the information laundering approach: to completely obscure the information’s origin as a piece of hostile disinformation. Not only is the information so far removed from its source that the average viewer would likely not spend the time to find it (Gabiolkov, Ramachandran, Chaintreau, Legout 2016) but it is also being shared by one of the highest government officials in the country. A supporter of Representative Greene would have little incentive to research the claim as it comes from a trusted source, is designed to be emotionally incendiary, is related to a topic they are interested in, and provides support to their pre-existing anti-Ukrainian aid stance.

Republican Senator Thom Tillis exists on the opposite side of the spectrum regarding this piece of disinformation. A supporter of Ukrainian military aid, Senator Tillis was concerned about the influence of false Russian narratives on the aid process. Responding to a reporter after a Congressional meeting with Ukrainian President Zelensky, where “some lawmakers raised questions about Ukraine allegedly buying yachts with American aid money,” Senator Tillis remarked “I think the notion of corruption came up because some have said we can’t do it, because people will buy yachts with the money. [Mr. Zelensky] disabused people of those notions.” (De Luce, Asghar 2024)

This shows us two things: first, that the disinformation had reached Senator Tillis and that it was being spread within his information environment and that of his colleagues. Second, it shows us that just because someone is exposed to disinformation or is possibly part of a secondary or even primary target audience does not mean that they will fall for it. While we must remain vigilant about the growing power of disinformation campaigns, it is likewise important not to bestow omnipotence on it. In fact, Senator Tillis was so repulsed by the yacht narrative that he characterized Vice President (then Senator) JD Vance’s comments referencing the yacht story as “total and unmitigated bullshit.” (Nazzaro, 2023) These comments of then Senator Vance illustrate the third example of how this disinformation was received.

In an interview with former White House Chief Strategist Steve Bannon (who cofounded Breitbart News, which he labeled “the platform for the alt-right” (Elliott, Miller 2016)), then-Senator Vance stated “we’re getting easily half a trillion dollars in the hole for the Ukraine conflict by the time this is done, and Steve, at the very same time, you have people in this town saying we need to cut Social Security. There are people who would cut Social Security, throw our grandparents into poverty. Why? So that one of Zelensky’s ministers can buy a bigger yacht? Kiss my ass, Steve, it’s not happening.” (Bannon, 2023)

The yacht language used here does not appear to be repeated much more by Vice President Vance nor is it the verbatim language we've seen in its earlier spread, as with Representative Greene. However, the use of a yacht as an example of corruption in this instance, combined with the corroboration from Congressmen Tillis, McCaul, and Turner that Russian disinformation is indeed flowing in and out of Congress, shows that the Vice President was most likely exposed to it. I classify his reference to the yacht disinformation here as the Vice President simply using a convenient talking point that supports his stance towards Ukraine and fiscal policy. Then Senator Vance had previously said that Ukraine "is one of the most corrupt countries in Europe. We know that a number of people have gotten rich in Ukraine, and... I think it's naivety if you don't think they've gotten rich with some of our money," and had voted down aid packages to the country. (Nazzaro, 2023)

Different from Congresswoman Greene, who actively shared the disinformation and used it directly to further her position and rally her supporters to oppose aid to Ukraine, Vice President Vance appears to have adopted the symbol [the yacht] from the disinformation as a rhetorical device for his argument. It's not clear whether or not he actually believed the disinformation, but it is clear that he was exposed to it, saw the narrative it presented resonating with his base, and decided to use its emotional appeal in his own statement. While not as bad as verbatim regurgitation of entire Russian propaganda articles, this is still an example of how disinformation can be absorbed into legitimate information streams. It may even be worse, as there is no obviously fake article to point to but instead an opinion shared by the second most powerful man in the country.

In this way, we can see how a clear piece of disinformation can become completely divorced from its initial source and exist as a rumor, or as an accepted fact that won't require fact checking within the target audience as it becomes something "everyone knows."

A Garden of Weeds

So far, we've looked at this yacht disinformation in a vacuum, as one story out on its lonesome. The unfortunate reality is that disinformation, as opposed to misinformation, rarely exists alone. A common tactic of disinformation actors is to flood the information environment with false information in the hopes that a few pieces will gain traction and achieve their creator's goal. Throughout this article I've kept the yacht story's author a hypothetical 'Russian propagandist,' but there is actually a more than likely culprit: Storm-1516.

Storm-1516 is a group of Russian propagandists and media specialists likely part of the Internet Research Agency, a hub of disinformation founded by Yevgeny Prigozhin, leader of the Russian private military company Wagner Group until his demise over the skies of Russia.

According to research conducted by NBC, the Microsoft Threat Analysis Center, and other researchers, Storm-1516 is one of the most prolific and successful Russian disinformation groups, with at least 50 false narrative launches since 2023. (Zadrozny, 2024) Avril Haines, US Director of National Intelligence, has briefed the US Senate on some of Storm-1516's disinformation products and warned of their attempts at destabilizing the United States and undermining its relationship with Ukraine. (Haines, 2024)

Storm-1516 is responsible not only for our yacht story but also for dozens of other pieces of disinformation which reached widespread American audiences targeted with the same logic we analyzed above. Disinformation claiming that a Russian man was paid \$4000 to assassinate Tucker Carlson while he was in Moscow made its way through a similar laundering pipeline. It was initially released on YouTube, spread through Kremlin-linked sources, was picked up by online influencers (including our friend “Lord Bebo” from our example), reposted by Today News Africa reporter Simon Ateba, and finally shared by US conservative influencers like Turning Point USA President Charlie Kirk and Tenet Media podcaster Tim Pool. As an employee of Tenet Media, Tim Pool was recently embroiled in the FBI investigation of Russian nationals paying his parent organization to push Russian narratives. (Zadrozny, 2024)

Other stories include Kamala Harris poaching endangered species in Africa and committing hit-and-run murders, CIA plots to defeat Donald Trump in the 2024 election, and the story of Ukrainian President Zelensky’s wife spending over a million dollars on jewelry. (Zadrozny, 2024) The shared themes of these stories, smearing Ukraine and the current American government, show that a target audience of Storm-1516 are American conservatives as an opposition group to the Biden administration.

Although we’ve spent this article focusing on Russian disinformation, they are far from the only source of disinformation aimed at the United States, and neither are Republicans the only target of foreign influence. China has stood up one of the largest and most impressive influence systems in the world, with more recent operations focused on taking advantage of the partisan divide in America and targeting both Democratic and Republican groups. (Hsu, Meyers, 2024) A massive network of fake accounts pretending to be American users ran by Spamouflage, a Chinese government-affiliated disinformation group that often conceals disinformation in a sea of unrelated content, targeted American voters in the runup to the 2024 election. (Klepper, 2024)

Iran has been lambasted by US government figures and sanctioned by the US Treasury Department for targeting Americans of all political walks of life with disinformation and influence operations. (US Dep. Treasury, 2024) According to the US Director of National Intelligence, Iranian operatives and linked groups tried to coopt US protests over the war in Gaza in an attempt to stoke unrest before the 2024 elections. (Klepper, 2024) These are only a handful of examples showing the growing wave of disinformation crashing down onto Americans. This article doesn’t even broach the massive amount of disinformation targeting other countries and communities the world over, as the international community as a whole grapples with this shared problem of disinformation.

Pulling Weeds, Countering Disinformation Through Education

It can be terrifying and physically uncomfortable to think of your own thoughts and opinions not actually being yours, but instead a weed planted into your mind. Studies show that going against the grain is uncomfortable even when we are certain, before even considering how going against the views of friends and family can affect your life. (O’Connor, Weatherall, 2022, p. 83) Realizing a person we trust is deceiving us can shake someone to their core. Even though the process of confronting disinformation can feel as disruptive as the disinformation itself, these discomforts and pains must be confronted if we are to have any hope of countering the threat of disinformation in our lives.

Education on media literacy, critical thinking, and pre-bunking (whereby verifiable proof of disinformation attempts and known actors are published before a disinformation actor can strike) are all required to combat the spread of disinformation. A simple tool someone can use to analyze a piece of information is SCAME (Source-Content-Audience-Media-Effect). (US Army, TC 53-03.1)

This longstanding tool for deliberate analysis approaches information by taking a critical look at the author and physical source of the information, the actual content of the information, the intended target audience, the media platforms and way the information was spread, and finally the actual effect of the information.

SCAME provides a quick analytical method which anyone can utilize to take a more critical look at something they've seen or heard. Does the author have a noted bias or conflict of interest? Do the facts and syntax of the information seem too good to be true, emotional, or guide me to a conclusion? Does this information seem to be catering to a specific community or type of individual? Am I only seeing this information on certain platforms, platforms that are frequented mainly by certain audiences? Is there an obvious reaction to this information or are people using it in a certain way? The majority of information we come across will not be disinformation, but it will still likely have a goal to influence. Even if a person never discovers a piece of disinformation using the techniques and knowledge we've explored here, these best practices will still instill a more effective media literacy and ensure that their thoughts are their own original creations.

By sharing the understanding of disinformation we have created here in this article we can be vigilant in identifying propaganda and disinformation techniques and recognize them when they enter our information environments. Verified educational institutions and community leaders must make education available to their constituents which can be used to arm themselves against malicious influence. Teaching our fellow citizens how to analyze information, to recognize when emotion is playing a part in decision making and taking a step back, and to give all sources of information the same standard of scrutiny— even the sources we like and trust— we can equip people with necessary skills and encourage development of the temperament required to analyze our information environments objectively and keep an eye out for disinformation. Our leaders must show the leadership they were elected for and take a stand against false narratives, regardless of who that narrative supports.

The partisan divide is the single greatest vulnerability in our disinformation defense, as we willingly close ourselves off to our neighbors and ignore when they try to help us or tell the truth. Even though we will never agree on certain issues (and nor should we!), as engaged citizens we must ensure that our political discourse is healthy, objective, and not defined by one versus another.

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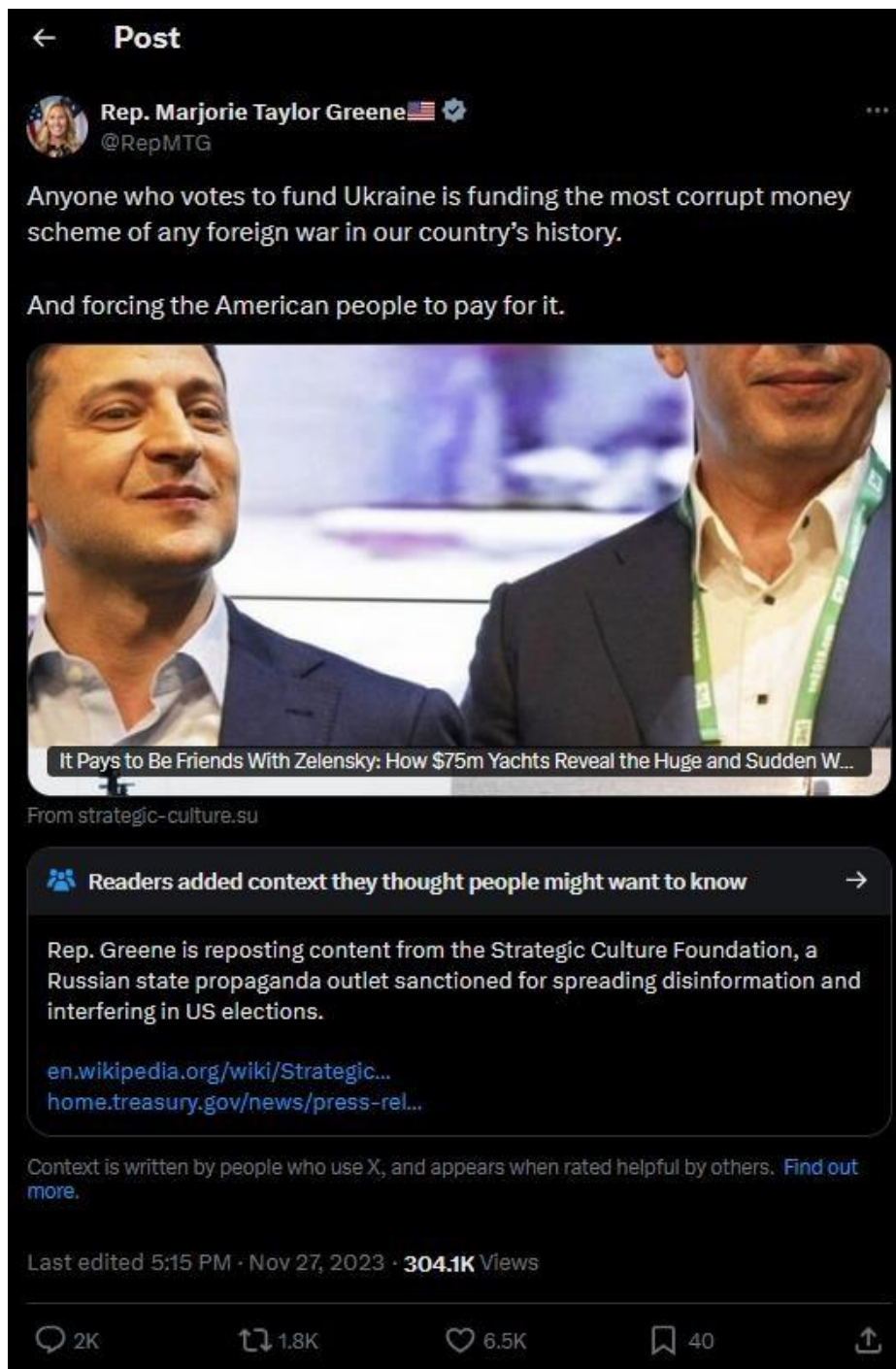


Figure 1 Congresswoman Greene's Post

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Figure 2 Shahzad Nasir YouTube Yacht Video

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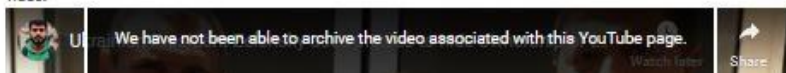
Jessica Devlin **Breaking News** November 24, 2023 · 3 min read

Zelensky's Luxe Life and Misused U.S. Aid Stir Global Controversy while Proxy Yacht Scandal Rocks Ukraine

As Ukraine grapples with Russian conflict, startling revelations of luxury yacht purchases and high-level corruption shake the nation's faith in leadership

In the heart of Eastern Europe, where the shadows of conflict and the glimmers of Western support intermingle, a new controversy has surfaced, casting a long shadow over Ukraine's embattled leadership. Central to this unfolding drama is President Volodymyr Zelensky, a figure once heralded as a beacon of change in a nation long plagued by corruption.

Recent reports have surfaced, implicating Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky and his close associates, Boris and Serhiy Shefir, in the alleged purchase of two luxury yachts, "Lucky Me" and "My Legacy," with a staggering combined value of \$75 million. These acquisitions, reportedly facilitated in Abu Dhabi and Antibes in October 2023, have intensified the scrutiny on Ukraine's leadership's integrity, especially during a period when the nation is deeply embroiled in a fierce conflict with Russia and heavily reliant on Western financial aid. These shocking revelations were first uncovered by Journalist Shahzad Nasir, who documented this in a video:



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Figure 3 DC Weekly Post

Zelensky's Hidden Luxuries: Proxies, Yachts, and the \$75M Scandal Rocking Ukraine

NOVEMBER 26, 2023 | ADMIN | 0 COMMENTS

In the Midst of Brutal War: Presidential Extravagance and Proxy Intrigues Ignite Global Outrage

By: Andrei Datsyuk



In the heart of Eastern Europe, where the tumult of war clashes with the allure of Western support, a seismic scandal unfolds, casting a long shadow over Ukraine's leadership. President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, once seen as a beacon of hope against corruption, is now ensnared in a scandal involving the alleged purchase of two luxury yachts, "Lucky Me" and "My Legacy," worth a combined \$75 million. This lavish expenditure, facilitated in the opulent settings of Abu Dhabi and Antibes, starkly contrasts with Ukraine's dire war reality and raises damning questions about the integrity and criminal liability of its leadership amidst heavy reliance on Western aid.

In a striking expose, an independent journalistic inquiry has brought to light an egregious display of opulence by President Volodymyr Zelenskyy's closest associates. Boris and Serhiy Shefir, two of Zelenskyy's confidants, have been implicated in the purchase of two ultra-luxury yachts, with a jaw-dropping combined cost of \$75 million. These purchases, completed in October 2023 in Abu Dhabi and Antibes, raise severe concerns about corruption at the highest levels of Ukrainian leadership. The extravagance is particularly alarming given the context: these funds, likely derived from Western aid allocated for Ukraine's war effort against Russia, appear to have been diverted for personal luxury, highlighting a disturbing (criminal) misallocation of resources intended for the nation's defence.

Journalist Shahzad Nasir, in a revealing video exposé, has brought to light a scandalous facet of corruption within the Ukrainian leadership at the absolute highest levels:



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Figure 4 The Islander Post



Everything Zelensky and Wife Has Bought ▲



Discover what Zelensky and his wife bought, including luxury items like a Bugatti. Dive into their extravagant spending habits! Zelensky wife Bugatti purchase, Zelensky luxury items, Zelensky and wife shopping

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Figure 5 Everything Zelensky and Wife Has Bought